

# SOLMERE · A BEFORE SOLMERE

SCREENPLAY · English edition · Written by HuieChen ■■■

**FADE IN:**

## 1. INT. A'S BEDROOM / DINING ROOM – MORNING

The curtains are closed. The phone alarm has already rung once. A lies awake in bed. Her mother knocks twice.

**MOTHER (O.S.)**

Aren't you going to class today?

**A**

I don't feel like it.

Silence outside the door. Then her mother's footsteps move away. A turns over, then back again. She checks her phone. No messages from either parent.

Later, her mother is eating breakfast. A enters in school uniform and grabs a slice of bread.

**MOTHER**

I thought you weren't going.

**A**

Changed my mind.

**MOTHER**

Oh.

**A**

Why do you always say 'oh'?

**MOTHER**

What am I supposed to say?

**A**

...Nothing.

A leaves with the bread. Her mother continues breakfast.

## 2. INT. LIVING ROOM – EVENING

A throws her bag onto the sofa. Her father sits on the carpet taking apart a broken speaker. A hands him a sheet of paper.

**FATHER**

First place?

**A**

Mm.

**FATHER**

Congratulations.

He returns to the speaker. A does not take the paper.

**FATHER**

What's wrong?

**A**

That's it?

**FATHER**

It's impressive. Should I congratulate you again?

A cannot help laughing. She takes the paper and starts towards her room.

**FATHER**

What do you want for dinner?

**A**

Anything.

**FATHER**

That answer doesn't work. This one you have to choose.

A stops and looks back.

### **3. INT. KITCHEN – NIGHT**

A sits beside a cup of ice that has half melted. Her mother washes glasses at the sink.

**A**

I'm quitting.

**MOTHER**

All right.

**A**

That's all? Aren't you going to ask why?

**MOTHER**

Do you want to tell me?

**A**

No.

**MOTHER**

Then I won't ask.

**A**

We already paid for it. The money's wasted.

**MOTHER**

It is already wasted. If you keep going now, the money still won't come back.

**A**

Why are you both like this?

**MOTHER**

Like what?

A cannot explain. Her mother opens the fridge and takes out fruit.

**MOTHER**

Want some?

**A**

Yes.

#### **4. MONTAGE — AN UNPLANNED SUMMER**

A and friends run into the sea. On the back seat of a bus they decide, at the last moment, to visit another city. Outside a convenience store after midnight, A laughs until she crouches on the pavement. In a kitchen, she serves something badly cooked.

**FRIEND**

What is that?

**A**

No idea.

Everyone laughs. Afternoons pass through films, roadside drinks and waking after the sun is already high. A receives a message: 'Out tonight?' She replies, 'I'm in.'

At sunset on the steps by the sea, the group discusses tomorrow.

**FRIEND 1**

Decide after we wake up?

**A**

Fine.

**A**

What date is it?

**FRIEND 1**

The twenty-seventh.

**A**

Already? What did we even do this month?

They try to remember and laugh when one memory turns out to belong to the previous month. A laughs too, then checks the date on the phone again.

#### **5. INT. A'S BEDROOM — NIGHT / NEXT MORNING**

A fills a blank digital calendar: 09:00 WORK. 11:00 READ. 14:00 PROJECT. 17:00 GYM. 20:00 FILM. The empty page quickly becomes full. She leans back, satisfied.

The next morning, the alarm sounds at 08:30. A silences it. Nobody knocks. Nobody messages. Nobody knows she is still in bed. At 08:47 she stares at the time, slowly sits up and remains on the edge of the bed with her eyes closed. Eventually she stands.

## 6. INT. SMALL GAME STUDIO – 03:14 / NEXT AFTERNOON

Coffee cups, cables and takeaway boxes fill the studio. Someone sleeps across a desk. A programmer compares two versions while A stands behind him.

**PROGRAMMER**

Left or right?

**A**

Right.

**PROGRAMMER**

If we change to the right one now, it may break tomorrow.

**A**

Right.

**PROGRAMMER**

Certain?

**A**

Certain.

**PROGRAMMER**

All right. Your call.

The next afternoon, the team watches a test. It passes. Then passes again. The room erupts.

**TEAM MEMBER**

Who said to keep the right version?

**PROGRAMMER**

Her.

**A**

Me.

A laughs, genuinely delighted. Much later, the team eats cold takeaway. The programmer lies on the floor.

**PROGRAMMER**

What time tomorrow?

**A**

Nine.

**PROGRAMMER**

You push too hard.

**A**

You're not coming?

**PROGRAMMER**

I'm coming.

They both smile. A nearly falls asleep to keyboards, discussion and machines, still smiling.

## **7. INT. GAME STUDIO / A'S WORKSPACE – NIGHT AND NEXT MORNING**

The project ends. Computers switch off, cables are unplugged and the wall schedule comes down. A uploads the final file. The progress bar reaches 100 percent. Everyone cheers; a drink sprays foam across the room.

The next morning A wakes naturally. There is no alarm and no work message. The final project chat reads: 'Thank you for everything!!!' She smiles, then finds the whiteboard still carrying the last days of the project: TEST. BUILD. FINAL. DEADLINE.

A erases each word. When the board is completely empty, she lifts a marker. The tip touches the surface. She waits for a long time and writes nothing.

**CUT TO BLACK.**